



Spanish Language and Literature I · 1st year of Bachillerato · How we understand each other · Class 2 of 7 · With Vera

Doing things with words



Class video: <https://youtu.be/WG9IxBBjuC0>

The code leads to the video.

Name: _____ Date: _____

The class is about Spanish, so the examples stay in Spanish, with their meaning in English in brackets.

Before you start

1. Write down three things you have done today just with words, spoken or written. "Talking" doesn't count: what did you do by talking?
2. **At the end of the class.** Go back to your list. What kind of act was each one: assertive, directive, commissive, expressive or declaration? Did you do any of them indirectly?

While you watch the video

1. What is the difference between the meaning of a sentence and its sense? Answer before Vera says it.

2. **Your prediction.** «Te prometo que mañana te devuelvo el libro» ("I promise I'll give you the book back tomorrow") and «Ana me prometió que me devolvía el libro» ("Ana promised me she'd give me the book back"). Can both of them be false? What would have to happen for each one to be false?

3. If you write «Dispongo» ("I decree") in your notebook, no curriculum changes. If the words are the same, what fails?

4. «Mañana hay examen» ("There's an exam tomorrow"), said by your teacher at the end of class. What does she say? What does she do in saying it? What does she achieve?

5. What act does each one do? «Gracias por venir» ("Thanks for coming"). «¿Me dejas tu cargador?» ("Will you lend me your charger?"). «Te nombro capitana» ("I appoint you captain"), said by the team's coach. «Te prometo que no la vi» ("I promise I didn't see it").

6. In the conversation about the butter, which act does the other girl understand in each of the three questions? What do you base your answer on?

«Te prometo que no la vi», the conversation about the butter and the «¿tienes hora?» ("Got the time?") in the video are real, from the ESLORA corpus (Universidade de Santiago de Compostela, <http://eslora.usc.es>), under a CC BY-NC 4.0 licence. The other examples are invented.

Does it go right or wrong?

For each case: does the act actually happen? If it goes wrong, what fails? Use Austin's conditions: the right people and circumstances, doing it completely and correctly, sincerity... and the stage.

Case	Does the act happen?	What fails?
One bus passenger says to another: «Queda usted multado» ("You're fined").		

Case	Does the act happen?	What fails?
You apologise to your brother because your father tells you to, without meaning it.		
At a rehearsal of a play, an actor says: «Te prometo que volveré» ("I promise I'll come back").		
The coach says «Te nombro capitana» ("I appoint you captain") to a girl who has come to watch the match and isn't on the team.		
Someone writes in the class group chat «Mañana os paso los apuntes» ("I'll send you all the notes tomorrow"), and the next day doesn't send them.		
Your friend tells you: «Te prometo que ayer no salí» ("I promise I didn't go out yesterday").		

All the cases are invented.

Act hunters in the BOE

Open a text in Spain's Official State Gazette, the BOE (<https://www.boe.es>), and look for the point where the text stops explaining and starts doing.

Text (and date)	The word or formula that does something, copied exactly	Who is speaking?	What does it do? (kind of act)	Who else has to take part, according to the text itself?

For each formula: what would happen if someone else wrote it? Is it in the first person of the present tense?

Practice

1. What act does each utterance do, and is it direct or indirect? «¿Puedes bajar la música?» ("Can you turn the music down?"). «¡Enhorabuena por el carné!» ("Congratulations on your driving licence!"). And «Me queda un cinco por ciento de batería» ("I've only got five percent battery left"), said to someone holding a charger.
2. Why does each act fail? A student writes «Aprobado» ("Pass") on their own exam. At a civil wedding, the mayor asks both of them whether they consent, and only one answers. And someone promises to pay you back with no intention at all of doing it.
3. Find in your messages a request of yours made indirectly. Write down its form, the act it was doing and what the reader had to infer. Only messages written by you: you don't need to show the conversation or say who you were writing to. Keep it: you'll need it in the lab in the next class.

Keep thinking

A «me gusta» (a "like") on social media: what act does it do? And can it go wrong?